

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 4

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: The narrator, a teenage volunteer, describes her first afternoon at an animal shelter, where she tries to coax a frightened rescue dog out of its kennel.

1

The shelter smelt of bleach and warm fur, and of something else I could not name — the thin, sour smell of fear. I had arrived twenty minutes early in a clean T-shirt, full of the easy kindness of someone who had not yet been tested. Mrs Tan, the volunteer coordinator, looked at me over her clipboard and asked, without smiling, whether I was sure. I said I was. She handed me a slip of paper with a single name on it: **Biscuit**. She said he had been with them for fourteen weeks, and that he had not, in all that time, let any human come within arm's reach.

2

The kennel was at the far end of the row. Biscuit was the colour of old caramel, with a torn ear and ribs that showed faintly beneath a thin coat. He had folded himself into the back corner, as small as a dog of his size could make himself, and was watching me with eyes that were not so much frightened as resigned, as though he had already decided how this would end. I sat down cross-legged at the open door, two arm-lengths away. He did not move. The clean T-shirt suddenly felt absurd.

3

For perhaps ten minutes I said nothing at all. I had been told that words, in the early stages, meant very little; what mattered was the shape one made in the air, and whether that shape promised harm. I tried to make a small, dull shape — knees up, hands quiet, eyes anywhere but on him. Once or twice I caught myself holding my breath, and let it out slowly, the way the leaflet had told me to. Biscuit's eyes followed the breath out of my mouth and back in again. He did not blink.

4

After a long time I took a single piece of chicken from the paper bag at my hip and laid it on the concrete halfway between us. I did not look at it. I did not look at him. I looked, with great concentration, at a crack in the wall behind his head. Several minutes passed. Then, without any sound at all, he was

beside the chicken, and then the chicken was gone, and then he was back in his corner, smaller, somehow, than before. I had not seen him move. The whole encounter had taken less than two seconds. I felt, ridiculously, like crying.

5

I did this for an hour. Each piece a fraction closer. Each time, the same silent flicker — chicken there, chicken gone, dog back in the corner, watching. After the seventh piece my legs had gone numb and my back ached and I began, in a small ungenerous part of myself, to resent him. I had imagined, when I signed up, a different sort of afternoon — one in which the frightened dog crept forward, sniffed my hand, and laid its head, eventually, on my knee. The leaflet had warned me against this fantasy. I had not, properly, believed the leaflet.

6

Mrs Tan walked past at one point and said, very quietly, “He is letting you stay. That is the work.” I did not understand at the time. I understood only that my knees hurt and that I had two more pieces of chicken left and that the dog had still not let me touch him, would perhaps never let me touch him, and that the kindness I had brought with me — clean, easy, T-shirt kindness — was not the kindness that was being asked of me here.

7

On the last piece, I made a mistake. I shifted my weight too quickly and my knee scraped the concrete with a small dry sound. Biscuit was on his feet before I had finished moving, pressed flat against the wall, his lip lifted just enough to show a single yellow tooth. He was not, I realised, threatening me. He was begging me, in the only language he had, to stop being a danger. I went very, very still. I lowered my eyes. I made myself, as far as I could, into a piece of furniture. After a long time, he sat down again.

8

When my shift ended, Biscuit was still in his corner. He had not, by any measure I had brought with me that morning, made progress. And yet, walking out into the bright car park, I found that I was thinking not about him but about myself — about how I had imagined I would be the one giving, and had instead been quietly taught. The clean T-shirt was no longer clean. I was, I realised, no longer quite the same person who had put it on.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator describes herself as having “the easy kindness of someone who had not yet been tested.” Explain, in your own words, what this phrase tells us about her attitude before her shift began. [2]

2. Mrs Tan “looked at me over her clipboard and asked, without smiling, whether I was sure.” What does Mrs Tan’s behaviour suggest about her view of the volunteer at this moment? [2]

From Paragraph 2

3. The narrator says Biscuit’s eyes “were not so much frightened as resigned.” Explain, in your own words, what this tells us about the dog. [2]

4. At the end of Paragraph 2 the narrator says, “The clean T-shirt suddenly felt absurd.” What does this sentence reveal about how her feelings have changed? [2]

From Paragraph 3

5. The narrator says that what mattered “was the shape one made in the air, and whether that shape promised harm.” Explain the meaning of this description in your own words. [2]

From Paragraph 4

6. When Biscuit takes the chicken, the narrator writes that “the whole encounter had taken less than two seconds.” Explain how the writer’s language in Paragraph 4 conveys the **speed and silence** of the dog’s movement. Support your answer with **two** details from the paragraph. [3]

From Paragraph 5

7. The narrator admits to feeling, “in a small ungenerous part of myself,” resentful of Biscuit. What does this admission tell us about her character? [2]

8. The narrator says she “had not, properly, believed the leaflet.” Why has the writer placed the word **properly** between two commas? [1]

From Paragraph 6

9. Mrs Tan says, “He is letting you stay. That is the work.” Explain, in your own words, what Mrs Tan means. [2]

From Paragraph 7

10. The narrator realises Biscuit “was begging me, in the only language he had, to stop being a danger.” What does this realisation suggest about how her understanding of the dog has changed? [1]

From Paragraph 8

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]

Text 4: A feature article on how urban green spaces affect mental health and community well-being in densely built cities.

1

Cities, even the most carefully planned among them, are not natural environments for the human animal. They are loud, hard-surfaced, crowded, and lit at hours when our bodies expect darkness. It is unsurprising, then, that the small patches of greenery within them — a corner park, a tree-lined avenue, a strip of community garden squeezed between two blocks of flats — carry a weight quite disproportionate to their size. A growing body of evidence suggests that these modest spaces are not merely pleasant. They are, for many city dwellers, a quiet but essential form of public health.

2

The science is, by now, surprisingly settled. A 2019 review of more than 140 studies, published in the journal **Environmental Research**, found that regular contact with urban green space was associated with significantly lower levels of cortisol, the body's principal stress hormone. Researchers at the University of Exeter, tracking 10,000 city residents over five years, reported that those who moved to greener neighbourhoods experienced a measurable improvement in mental well-being that **persisted** for at least three years afterwards. The mechanism, psychologists believe, has two parts. The first is what is called “attention restoration”: the soft, undemanding stimulus of leaves, water and bird sound allows the brain's overworked focusing systems to rest. The second is simpler — green spaces invite us, gently, to walk, to sit, and to meet our neighbours.

3

That second effect deserves more attention than it usually receives. A park is, after all, one of the very few public places where strangers may legitimately spend an afternoon without buying anything. A child learns to ride a bicycle in front of an audience of pensioners. A grandmother practises a slow morning exercise as joggers wave past. A teenager who would rather die than be seen with her parents nevertheless agrees, on a weekend, to lie on the grass beside them. None of these encounters, on their own, is consequential. Cumulatively, they are the **connective tissue** of a neighbourhood.

4

Yet access to this quiet form of medicine is, in most cities, profoundly unequal. A 2021 study of major Asian metropolises found that wealthier districts enjoyed, on average, almost **four times** the green space per resident as poorer ones. The pattern is repeated across the world: leafier neighbourhoods tend to be richer, healthier, and longer-lived, while denser, hotter, treeless districts are home to those who can least afford private gardens or weekend trips out of the city. The injustice of this is, to anyone who has stood on a treeless concrete street in a tropical afternoon, very plain.

5

Design matters too — and not all green space is equal. A wide, manicured lawn closed to the public is, for the purposes of public health, almost worthless. A small, well-shaded plaza with a bench, a drinking fountain, and a path that an elderly resident can manage on a walking stick is, by every measure researchers have devised, worth several times its size in social and psychological benefit. What planners now call “pocket parks” — green spaces of a few hundred square metres, threaded into the existing fabric of a neighbourhood — appear to deliver disproportionate gains. They are cheap, fast to build, and, crucially, close enough to people's homes that they are used on weekday evenings, not only on Sunday afternoons.

6

City planners have, belatedly, begun to listen. Singapore's “City in a Garden” programme has, over two decades, raised the island's tree canopy cover to a level that researchers from other tropical cities

now travel to study. Paris has committed to planting 170,000 new trees by 2030 and to converting four major squares into “urban forests”. Bogotá, Medellín and Seoul have replaced elevated motorways with linear parks, with measurable cooling and mental-health benefits in surrounding districts. None of this is glamorous work — it is, frankly, a matter of soil, drains and patient horticulture — but its effect on the everyday quality of urban life is hard to overstate.

7

There are, of course, limits. A tree is not a substitute for affordable housing, decent schools, or clean air at the citywide scale. Green space cannot, on its own, undo the structural inequalities of a city; nor will it persuade a stressed commuter who never sees the sun. But the evidence suggests that, within those limits, it does a great deal — quietly, cheaply, and for everyone who walks past. To plant a tree in a poor street is, in this sense, one of the most modest and most radical things a city can do.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer says that cities “are not natural environments for the human animal.” Explain, in your own words, what this phrase suggests about how the writer views city life. [2]

From Paragraph 2

13. According to Paragraph 2, give **two** pieces of scientific evidence that green spaces benefit mental health. [2]

14. Explain, in your own words, what is meant by “attention restoration.” [2]

From Paragraph 3

15. The writer calls everyday park encounters “the connective tissue of a neighbourhood.” Why are the words **connective tissue** placed in italics, and what is the effect? [2]

16. The writer says that “a park is... one of the very few public places where strangers may legitimately spend an afternoon without buying anything.” What does this tell us about the writer’s view of most other public spaces in a city? [2]

From Paragraph 4

17. The writer says that the inequality of green space is “to anyone who has stood on a treeless concrete street in a tropical afternoon, very plain.” What is the **effect** of ending the paragraph in this way? [2]

From Paragraph 5

18. Explain, in your own words, why a “wide, manicured lawn closed to the public” is described as “almost worthless.” [2]

19. Give **two** reasons from Paragraph 5 why “pocket parks” are particularly effective. [2]

From Paragraph 6

20. The writer says that the work of planting and maintaining urban greenery “is, frankly, a matter of soil, drains and patient horticulture.” What is the writer’s **tone** in this sentence? [1]

From Paragraph 7

21. The writer ends the article by saying that planting a tree in a poor street is “one of the most modest and most radical things a city can do.” Explain what is **effective** about pairing the words **modest** and **radical** in this way. [2]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **the benefits of urban green spaces** and **the obstacles to providing them equitably**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 2 to 6** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Urban green spaces benefit city dwellers by ...

— END OF PAPER —